

Georgia's Governor Candidates Meet for Their Only TV Debate

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This election season, 36 states across the U.S. are holding elections for governor. A governor is the leader of a state's government. One of those states is Georgia, where the two main **candidates** met this week for their first and only **televised** debate.

The **candidates** are Keisha Lance Bottoms, a Democrat and former mayor of Atlanta, and Rick Jackson, a Republican businessman. Georgia is called a "purple" state, meaning it is not firmly controlled by either party. Jackson is slightly ahead in the **polls** right now, according to PBS NewsHour reporter Liz Landers.

The debate gave Georgia voters a chance to ask the **candidates** questions directly. Many topics were the same ones being discussed across the country. They included the cost of living, Flock cameras that read car license plates and are common in Atlanta, data centers, wage growth and expanding **Medicaid**, a government health insurance program.

Bottoms tried to connect Jackson to President Donald Trump. She said Jackson had claimed there was not a single policy he disagreed with Trump on. "My number one priority is Georgians," she said.

Jackson did not mention Trump by name. Instead, he compared himself to Georgia's current Republican governor, Brian Kemp. Trump has **endorsed** Jackson, though Jackson has not talked about that much lately.

Landers attended a watch party held by Republicans in Fulton County. Supporters there said they liked Jackson's business background and that he is not a longtime **politician**. Jackson also has a large money advantage and is running many TV ads.

Across the country, there are currently 26 Republican governors and 24 Democratic governors. Both parties see chances to win some governor races that the other party now holds.

Word Treasure

televised -- Shown on TV.

candidates -- People who are trying to be elected to a job.

polls -- Surveys that ask voters whom they plan to support.

Medicaid -- A government program that helps pay for health care for people with low incomes.

endorsed -- Publicly gave support to someone running for office.

politician -- A person whose job is in government or who runs for elected office.

Background you need

A governor is the elected leader of a U.S. state, somewhat like a president for one state. Governors are chosen by voters, and candidates often hold debates so voters can compare their ideas side by side.

Most U.S. candidates belong to one of two big political parties, the Democrats or the Republicans.

A purple state is one where voters are fairly evenly split between those two parties, so elections there can be close.

Break it down

LEAD: Georgia's two main candidates for governor held their first and only televised debate

KEY EVENT: Voters asked the candidates questions directly

+ WHO: Democrat Keisha Lance Bottoms and Republican Rick Jackson

+ TOPICS: Cost of living, Flock cameras, data centers, wage growth and Medicaid

+ CLASH: Bottoms tied Jackson to President Trump; Jackson compared himself to Governor Brian Kemp

EVIDENCE: Jackson slightly ahead in polls, with a large money advantage and many TV ads

CONTEXT: 36 states electing governors; 26 Republican and 24 Democratic governors now

OPEN QUESTION: Which party will win governor races the other now holds?

Why it matters

Governors make decisions about schools, roads and health programs, so these elections shape daily life in each state. Debates give voters a direct way to compare candidates.

Test what you remember

1. How many states are holding elections for governor this season?

- ☐ (A) 50
- ☐ (B) 36
- ☐ (C) 26
- ☐ (D) 24

2. Who is Keisha Lance Bottoms?

- ☐ (A) A PBS reporter
- ☐ (B) Georgia's current governor
- ☐ (C) A former mayor of Atlanta running as a Democrat
- ☐ (D) A Republican businessman

3. What does it mean that Georgia is a purple state?

- ☐ (A) It always votes Democratic
- ☐ (B) It has no governor
- ☐ (C) It is not firmly controlled by either party
- ☐ (D) It always votes Republican

4. Whom did Rick Jackson compare himself to?

- ☐ (A) A national news anchor
- ☐ (B) Brian Kemp
- ☐ (C) Keisha Lance Bottoms
- ☐ (D) Liz Landers

5. Which of these topics came up in the debate?

- ☐ (A) Data centers
- ☐ (B) Professional sports
- ☐ (C) School lunches
- ☐ (D) Space travel

6. What did Jackson's supporters at the watch party say they liked?

- ☐ (A) His business background and that he is not a longtime politician
- ☐ (B) His plan to move to Atlanta
- ☐ (C) His debate jokes
- ☐ (D) His years as mayor

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: A

1. **Keisha Lance Bottoms (Democrat):** Says her number one priority is Georgians and says Jackson has claimed he disagrees with no Trump policy.
2. **Rick Jackson (Republican):** Compares himself to current Republican Governor Brian Kemp instead of mentioning Trump.
3. **Jackson supporters at a Republican watch party:** Like his business background and that he is not a longtime politician.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):